Cannabis for Medical Use

PREVIOUS STUDENT

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PSY 440: Health Psychology

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NOTE: THIS WAS AN EARLIER VERSION OF THE PAPER, WHICH WAS COMPLETED INDIVIDUALLY. THE LENGTH/ DEPTH PER SOURCE WAS INCREASED WHEN THE PAPER SHIFTED TO A GROUP ASSIGNMENT.

Cannabis for Medical Use

Medical cannabis is a highly discussed topic in the healthcare system and has increasingly gotten more popular. It is often used to manage pain in a lot of chronic health disorders. This topic directly relates to health decisions as individuals must weigh potential risks and benefits when deciding if they want to use medical cannabis. However, this topic is highly controversial as one perspective supports the use of medical cannabis as an effective treatment, while another perspective argues that there isn't enough evidence and potentially has some safety risks. These conflicting viewpoints are important to take into consideration when understanding how information about medical cannabis is being communicated when making informed health decisions.

Journal Article by Hsu and Associates (2026)

This article gives insight on the number of people who use medical cannabis and the size of its effect. It states that "approximately 27% of adults...report having ever used cannabis for medical purposes" (Hsu et al., 2026). Additionally, the article reports quantified outcomes on standard mean difference dealing with reduced nausea, ultimately showing that the evidence is quantitative rather than isolated. Overall, the source relies on evidence as it uses data from meta-analyses and clinical trials. Small interpretations are also incorporated however, as phrases like "small but significant reduction" (Hsu et al., 2026) may have some influence on the reader and how important they think the data is. The purpose of the article is to explain current evidence from the FDA on uses that are approved and uses that are not approved to clinicians and researchers, rather than being persuasive to a general audience. The article has a mostly cautious tone, pointing out the limitations of the evidence forcing the readers to think more critically and cautious about the effects of cannabis use. Some potential bias arises when the article says,

"evidence is insufficient for most uses" (Hsu et al., 2026). The lack of strong evidence may cause readers to favor more well-proven treatments over newer ones that are still being experimented with.

Journal Article by Castle and Associates (2025)

In this article, information is combined from multiple studies- "over 10,000 papers with 39,767 data points" which shows that "support for medical cannabis is 31.38 times stronger than opposition" (Castle et al., 2025). Instead of giving the exact numbers from each study, the article focuses on overall trends and how they compare to each other. The article uses the author's opinions and mixes them with actual data that has been found. While it does show some numbers and agreement levels, it uses phrases such as "strong consensus" which can make the results seem more positive. The article appears to both persuade and inform a specific audience about how medical cannabis has therapeutic potential in the oncology field. This can be suggested by statements that suggest reevaluating medical use of cannabis its legal status within clinical settings. Overall, the tone is optimistic while also being assertive about the benefits that cannabis has, highlighting its anti-inflammatory aspects. This aspect may cause readers to view the use of cannabis more favorably, as it may seem more conclusive that it really is. Additionally, the repeated emphasis on "consensus supporting the use of medical cannabis" (Castle et al., 2025) may lead to more bias as no limitations were listed, showing only the positive side of using it.

Article by the New York Post (2025)

This article uses numbers from a UCLA led review using statistics such as "analyzed over 2,500 scientific papers" and "about 29% of medical cannabis users could meet criteria for cannabis use disorder" (Beard, 2025). Using these big numbers suggests broad risks to readers even though it doesn't address the study quality. Some factual data points are mentioned, but this

article places more emphasis on exceptional interpretation. With only limited evidence, the author encourages a negative outlook by using phrases like “hidden risks that may actually outweigh any benefits” (Beard, 2025) rather than stating the research. The article has a persuasive design and has goals to alarm the readers over cannabis usage instead of informing them about it. There is a selection of risk-focused findings as well as the use of the word “bombshell” which are both aimed at getting the reader's attention. This ties into the cautious tone, emphasizing the doubts and dangers of using medical cannabis. Phrases like “significant red flags” and “insufficient evidence” (Beard, 2025) have a problematic outlook and may make readers feel uncertain even if the original study was more measured. Some signs of bias may come from the use of dramatic wording as well as only highlighting negative outcomes leaning the readers more towards fear.

Article by Science Daily News (2025)

The article uses overarching trends saying that “medical cannabis use has increased significantly over the past decade” (2025) and that many patients report both side effects and benefits. Instead of using detailed results from the studies, it uses big picture numbers. Although the article mentions facts from the research studies, it spends more time explaining what they mean instead. Phrases like "scientific support...remains weak” (2025) are used and show how the authors are guiding the reader’s opinions without giving them the actual data. The article’s goal is to inform the public about medical cannabis, while also warning them about the risks of its use. It both educates and encourages caution about using cannabis, rather than just report the study. The overall tone is mostly cautious and points out uncertainties such as “evidence is uncertain for many uses” (2025). This may cause readers to be more doubtful about using medical cannabis. Since the article focuses more on risks than benefits, there is a bias towards

caution when using it. Words like “hidden risks” and an emphasis on weak evidence may make cannabis seem more risker than it is.

Article from The Guardian (2025)

The article looks at the size and scope of the research review, describing it as the “largest-ever study” (Green, 2025) on the topic. It also places emphasis on trends with broad potential instead of listing clinical outcomes, using scale to show strength. There is a mix of factual reports and interpretations in the article. It mentions research analysis however a lot of the article is focused on what the study actually means. Using phrasing like “to solidify agreement on cannabis’s potential” (Green, 2025) making the readers lean more towards the positive side of usage. The article appears to inform a wide audience on research that has been done, while also promoting interest in medical cannabis as a potential cancer treatment. The tone is very enthusiastic and provides an outlook on a potential breakthrough if cannabis were to be used to treat cancer. This may lead readers to view the topic as more hopeful than the science behind it may support. Bias may also come from this positive outlook on the study, as it doesn’t highlight as many limitations from using it. The quotes that the author uses may push the positive view of cannabis onto readers instead of giving a balanced perspective.

Critical Evaluation of Health Communication

Across all five sources that were looked at, bias in communicating health information can come from multiple different groups including journalists, researchers, and other scientific organizations. For example, some media-based articles used terms such as “bombshell” or “hidden risks” which can be emotionally triggering. On the flip side, more research-based articles used wording such as “strong consensus” or “insufficient evidence”, showing that both

media and academic sources may use wording rather than data when interpreting things to readers.

The source that a person reads has a strong impact on how they will interpret the research. Some articles emphasize extreme risks and benefits, which can lead to findings being interpreted as more dramatic, while other articles use more technical language and statistics that are more neutral. Although more evidence based, phrases are still used with this data to help guide readers' interpretation. As a result of this, the overarching topic of medical cannabis can be deemed as very beneficial or very risky depending on the source.

These differences in communication styles may lead to direct impacts on public health decisions. Tones that are more alarming may turn people away from considering using medical cannabis even though evidence may support the usage. In contrast, more optimistic sources may lead individuals to look too much into the benefits and not enough into the risks. A combination of these factors may lead to uniformed decisions, either by avoiding the use of medical cannabis or using it without proper guidance in doing so.

Altogether, when evaluating health information, there are several important factors to consider. These factors include quality of evidence, presentation of statistics, recognizing limitations, and the tone that is used. In addition to this, readers should also look at if risks and benefits are presented equally or are more one-sided. Overall, the analysis shows that the public should approach health information in a critical matter, recognizing that bias may be present, and should look at multiple sources before coming to a conclusion.

Reflection

While doing this assignment, I learned how information is interpreted and communicated. Often when doing research, people expect to learn facts about the topic they are studying, but

there is additional information other than facts that weigh into research. One thing that was surprising to me was how differently the topic of medical cannabis was presented, depending on the source. Many of these sources have similar research and data, however some leaned more towards the benefits of using cannabis, while others only focused on the risks. Something that really stood out to me throughout all of the articles is the wording and how much of an impact it can make. Emotional phrases can strongly influence readers more than they even realize. This made me more aware that when doing research, it is important to recognize that bias is still present, and looking at data and percentages may be more beneficial. Research articles aren't completely objective and should be carefully read when making health decisions. In the future when making my own health decisions, I will now be more aware of these things and look at multiple sources to ensure I can make the correct and informed decision.

References

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